

Piscidia erythrina (Fabaceae) Jamaica Dogwood

Description Deciduous tree or shrub growing to 49 ft (15 m). Compound leaves, blue to white flowers with red stripes, and winged seed pods.

Habitat & Cultivation Jamaica dogwood is native to the southern U.S., Central America, northern South America, and the Caribbean. It is grown mainly for its wood, which is used in boat-building. The root bark is stripped when the tree is felled.

Part Used Root bark.

Constituents Jamaica dogwood contains isoflavones, phytosterols, tannins, and organic acids. The isoflavones are antispasmodic.

History & Folklore The pounded bark and twigs have been used by Native Caribs and Afro-Caribbeans to stupefy fish.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Jamaica dogwood is a useful and undervalued remedy that acts both as a sedative and as a painkiller. It is chiefly employed in the treatment of insomnia and overexcitability, as it calms mental activity. It is also prescribed for nerve pain, toothache, and period pain. As an antispasmodic, it is useful for treating muscle spasms, especially in the back, and spasmodic respiratory ailments such as asthma and whooping cough.

Cautions Do not take Jamaica dogwood during pregnancy or if you are suffering from heart problems.

Pistacia lentiscus (Anacardiaceae) Mastic Tree

Description Multibranched perennial growing to 10 ft (3 m). Has small elliptical leathery leaves, clusters of reddish flowers, and round scarlet fruit that ripens to black.

Habitat & Cultivation Mastic tree is native to the Mediterranean region. It grows wild in scrub and on wasteground and is cultivated for its resin, which is collected from incisions made in the bark in summer and autumn.

Part Used Resin.

Constituents The resin contains alpha- and beta-masticoresins, a volatile oil (comprising mainly alpha-pinene), tannins, masticin, and mastic acid. Pinenes are strongly antiseptic.

History & Folklore Mastic resin was used by the ancient Egyptians for embalming the dead.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In the recent past, mastic resin was little used, but contemporary research indicates that this should be reconsidered. Traditionally mastic extracts have been taken for coughs and bronchitis, and applied to the skin for boils, sores, and ulcers. Recent studies point to

the gum resin being useful in treating and preventing atheroma (fatty deposits in the arteries), to have antifungal and liver-protective activity, and to aid in conditions such as arthritis and gout.

Related Species The pistachio is produced by *P. vera*, also native to the Mediterranean region.

Plantago major (Plantaginaceae) Common Plantain

Description Perennial plant growing to 10 in (25 cm). Has a basal rosette of broad, deeply veined leaves and dense clusters of tiny green flowers on spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Common plantain is native to Europe and temperate regions of Asia. Rarely cultivated, it is normally picked from the wild. The leaves are gathered throughout the summer.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Common plantain contains iridoids (such as aucubin), flavonoids (including apigenin), tannins, plant acids, and mucilage. Aucubin increases uric acid excretion by the kidneys; apigenin is anti-inflammatory.

History & Folklore In Gaelic, this herb is known as "the healing plant" because it was used in Ireland to treat wounds and bruises. It is a plant that has accompanied European colonization around the



Common plantain is a perennial herb that grows wild in temperate regions.

world—some Native Americans called it Englishman's foot," because it seemed to spring up in the footsteps of white settlers.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Common plantain quickly staunches blood flow and encourages the repair of damaged tissue. It is possible to use it as a substitute for comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138) in treating bruises and broken bones.

An ointment or lotion may be used to treat hemorrhoids, fistulae (abnormal passages in the skin), and ulcers. Taken internally, common plantain is diuretic, expectorant, and antimucus. It is commonly prescribed for conditions including gastritis, peptic ulcers, diarrhea, dysentery, irritable bowel syndrome, respiratory inflammation, loss of voice, and urinary tract bleeding.

Related Species Ribwort plantain (*P. lanceolata*) is used in the same way as common plantain. *Che qian cao* (*P. asiatica*) is used in Chinese medicine as a diuretic and to counter mucus.

Self-help Uses Allergic rhinitis with mucus, p. 300; Diarrhea, p. 318.

Plumbago zeylanica (Plumbaginaceae) Ceylon Leadwort

Description Evergreen shrub, often a climber, growing to 16 ft (5 m). Has oval pointed leaves, spikes of 5-petaled white flowers, and angled seed capsules.

Habitat & Cultivation Ceylon leadwort is native to southern India and Malaysia, and is now naturalized in much of Southeast Asia and in Africa. The leaves and root are gathered throughout the year.

Parts Used Leaves, root.

Constituents Ceylon leadwort contains apthaquinones, including plumbagin, and phytosterols.

History & Folklore In Africa, the juice of Ceylon leadwort is used as a tattoo dye.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Ceylon leadwort root is acrid and stimulates sweating, and is commonly used as a paste for skin infections such as ringworm and scabies. The paste is also applied as a counter-irritant to relieve rheumatic aches and pains. In India, extracts of the leaves and root are taken for digestive infections such as dysentery. In Nepal, a decoction of the root is used to treat baldness.

Related Species The root of European leadwort (*P. europaea*) has been used to treat toothache and, in the form of a poultice or plaster, back pain and sciatica.

⚠ **Cautions** Use only under professional supervision. Taken internally, the root may be toxic, and may induce abortion. Do not use Ceylon leadwort during pregnancy.